Anne of Green Gables

A simplified retelling

Original story by L. M. Montgomery

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. The wrong child

Matthew Cuthbert went to the station expecting a boy. He and his sister, Marilla, were growing older and wanted help on their farm, Green Gables. Instead, a thin girl with red hair sat waiting for him.

Her name was Anne Shirley. She talked almost without stopping on the journey home. Trees, water and the evening sky filled her with delight. Matthew, usually uncomfortable with strangers, found himself listening happily.

Marilla was less pleased. There had been a mistake, and she intended to correct it. Anne had already imagined that Green Gables would be her first real home. When she understood that she might be sent away, her happiness collapsed.

She had lived in homes where she was useful mainly for looking after younger children, and in an orphanage. Marilla gradually learned more of her history. A practical arrangement with another household began to look unkind.

The Cuthberts decided that Anne could stay. She did not

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know how to help on a farm, but she desperately wanted to belong.

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2. A name and a friendship

Anne disliked her red hair and wished she were beautiful. When the neighbour, Mrs Rachel Lynde, commented bluntly on her appearance, Anne answered angrily. Marilla insisted on an apology.

Apologising did not come easily, but Anne could give a performance when she chose. Her dramatic apology amused Mrs Lynde and began a more peaceful relationship.

Across the fields lived Diana Barry, a girl Anne hoped would become her closest friend. They made a serious promise of friendship and shared stories, games and imagined adventures.

At school, Gilbert Blythe pulled Anne’s hair and called her “Carrots.” Anne broke her slate over his head. He tried to apologise, but she refused to forgive him.

From then on, she competed with him in lessons. She would do almost anything to avoid admitting that she liked him. Rivalry gave her a reason to work hard, even when it also made her stubborn.

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3. Mistakes at Green Gables

Anne’s imagination could make ordinary days beautiful, but it could also distract her. When Marilla’s brooch disappeared, Anne was wrongly suspected of taking it. Wanting permission to attend a picnic, she invented a confession. The brooch was later found, and Marilla had to acknowledge her own mistake.

Another disaster came when Anne invited Diana to tea. Believing she was serving raspberry cordial, she gave her friend wine. Diana became unwell, and Mrs Barry forbade the friendship.

Anne was miserable. Then Diana’s little sister became seriously ill while the adults were away. Anne had cared for children before and knew what to do until help arrived.

Mrs Barry recognised her mistake and allowed the girls to be friends again. Anne’s unusual childhood, which had caused her so much pain, had also taught her something useful.

Marilla continued to correct Anne, but affection was becoming part of every correction.

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4. Adventures and consequences

Anne longed for black hair and bought a dye from a travelling seller. Her hair turned green. It had to be cut short, leaving her with another lesson in trusting exciting promises.

During a game inspired by a poem, she lay in a small boat and floated downstream. The boat began to sink. She caught hold of a bridge support and waited until Gilbert found her and brought her safely ashore.

He tried again to make peace. Anne thanked him but still refused his friendship.

There were happier occasions too: concerts, visits and the pleasure of discovering people who understood her imagination. Matthew noticed that Anne’s clothes were plainer than those of other girls. He quietly arranged for her to receive a dress with the puffed sleeves she admired.

Anne was overwhelmed. The gift mattered because someone had noticed a wish she had not expected to have granted.

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5. Learning to direct her energy

A new teacher, Miss Stacy, encouraged Anne and a group of students to prepare for further study. Anne’s energy began to find a steadier direction.

She still loved stories and beautiful names for ordinary places. But now she could work towards a future as well as imagine one. She and Gilbert continued to compete, usually near the top of the class.

Anne entered Queen’s Academy to train as a teacher. Leaving Green Gables was difficult, though she knew she wanted the opportunity. In the city, she studied hard and found comfort in friendships when she felt homesick.

At the end of the year, she won a scholarship that would allow her to continue her education at college. Matthew and Marilla were proud of her.

The child who had arrived as a mistake had become someone whose achievements belonged to the whole household. Anne looked ahead and saw a road full of possibilities.

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6. A bend in the road

Then Matthew died suddenly. News of financial trouble at the bank had brought a terrible shock to a man whose health was already weak.

Anne grieved for the quiet person who had accepted her before anyone else did. There was no imaginative name that could make his absence less real.

Marilla’s eyesight was also failing. She considered selling Green Gables because she could not manage alone. Anne decided to give up the scholarship for the present and teach nearby so that she could stay with her.

Gilbert had been offered the Avonlea school. When he learned of Anne’s situation, he gave it up and took another position, allowing her to work close to home.

Anne finally accepted his friendship. A childish insult no longer seemed worth carrying into the rest of her life.

She could not see exactly what lay beyond the next bend in the road. But she had a home, work she could do, people to love and more to learn. That was enough to take the next step.

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Words to keep

Orphan — a child whose parents have died. Anne had lived in an orphanage.

Imagination — the ability to create pictures or possibilities in your mind. Anne’s imagination transformed familiar places.

Rivalry — competition between people who want the same success. Her rivalry with Gilbert encouraged her studies.

Confession — admitting that you have done something wrong. Anne’s invented confession caused confusion.

Scholarship — financial support awarded for study. Anne won a scholarship at Queen’s.

Belong — to feel accepted as part of a place or group. At Green Gables, Anne finally felt she belonged.

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A question to carry with you

When has someone noticed a small wish or worry of yours? Why did that attention matter?

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